

Àkíyèsí

Yoruba, "observation, taking notice"

A way for the people closest to the street, the ones with no smartphone and no access to WhatsApp, to be heard before something happens, not just after.

Track: Stability & Social Cohesion

Secondary: Safety, Reporting & Protection

THE PROBLEM

A WhatsApp group locks out the people with the most to tell you

When I moved into the Orogun neighbourhood in Ibadan, there had been a rise in burglaries nearby, and a tip that the gang planning them was coming here next.

The neighbourhood responded fast: barrier gates went up, a curfew started, Amotekun (the regional security outfit) was hired to guard the streets, and a WhatsApp group was created to collect tips and push information back out.

It worked, up to a point. But it runs on smartphones and data. The people standing closest to the actual street at 2am, night guards, okada riders, traders, are exactly the ones it can't reach.

"Lots of banners around asking people on the street for information, with no actionable, stress-free way to actually share it."

What I kept seeing posted around Ibadan in the weeks after the Bodija explosion: appeal after appeal for information, with nowhere for anyone to actually send it.

0

smartphones you need to send
Àkíyèsí a report

1

smartphone you need just to join a
WhatsApp group

THE INSIGHT

There's an abundance of data in the air, locally, on the ground. There's no aggregator.

The value isn't a new app. It's reaching the people who are already closest to the ground, who don't have smartphone access, and giving what they notice somewhere to go.

One person noticing something odd says nothing on its own, and they'd feel foolish reporting it alone. But street-level observation is constant and it's happening whether or not anyone is collecting it.

THE SOLUTION

Text what you saw. A toll-free number, any phone. An LLM does the listening.

- SMS to a toll-free number, accessible on the most basic feature phone, no data plan, no app to download
- An LLM reads every message and filters noise without the bias a tired human volunteer would bring to it
- It's not judging any one report. It's watching for when the street tells the same story more than once

"Like Flock cameras, but leveraging human intelligence. Like 911, but government-free and simple to execute for people on the street."

Not another Ushahidi-style incident map: no public feed, no public accusations. It aggregates the weak signals that were never worth reporting on their own, not the standalone incidents that kind of map is built to publish.

HOW IT WORKS

Three steps, from a text message to a signal a committee can act on

1

Text what you saw

Behaviour, time, roughly where. Any phone, toll-free, no signup.

2

The LLM filters and groups

It throws out noise (a loud party, a lost goat), and quietly groups reports that describe the same emerging pattern.

3

Enough independent people notice it, it becomes a signal

Only once several unrelated senders describe the same thing does it reach the neighbourhood's own security committee, never on one report alone.

Under the hood, a few things were built to make this safe to actually run: an LLM is the first to read every report, stripping identity as it does, so identities are always protected, and there's a separate protected line for reporting the guards themselves. More on that on the "what's built" slide.

WHY IT MATTERS

This would have caught the Bodija explosion

16 January 2024, Bodija, Ibadan. Illegal miners had been storing explosives inside an occupied residential house. Neighbours had lived beside it for weeks. When it went off: 2 killed, 77 injured, more than 20 buildings damaged.

Same architecture, a different pattern definition.

The exact pipeline built for burglary casing, weak individual observations aggregated into a corroborated signal, generalises to any behaviour a community defines: unfamiliar drums being offloaded at night, a chemical smell, warehouse activity at 2am. What burglary casing is to a break-in, this is to an explosion nobody saw coming until it was too late.

SCALE

Texting is already the standard. That's what makes this scale.

Toll-free, so it costs nothing to report

No data plan, no airtime spent, no reason not to send the text. Posted on the same banners already asking the neighbourhood for information, and spread through community awareness campaigns.

One number per community

Every neighbourhood, campus or estate gets its own subnetwork tied to its own number and its own committee. Adding one is a config change, not new code.

Spreads on its own shape

From one estate in Ibadan, to the next one over, to a university campus, to any community that can name a committee to receive it.

NEXT

Voice comes next, and it needs nothing new

The same toll-free number, but reporters call it and leave a recorded message instead of texting, the way anyone already leaves a voicemail. No app, no data connection, no new number to remember, just a different way to use the line that's already there.

WHAT'S ALREADY BUILT

A working proof of concept, not just the idea

Six components, all working end to end today, with 165 automated tests: SMS intake, an identity-redaction layer, a normal/protected channel split, corroboration clustering, a verification desk with an audit trail, and a guard against profiling. Everything a community or a language needs is a config row, never a code change.

Meeting the brief's operating constraints

- ✓ **Trust & verification**
Noise filtered before a person sees it; every escalation carries an audit trail, who decided, on what evidence, when.
- ✓ **Accessibility & inclusion**
Toll-free removes the cost barrier; voice intake is next for lower-literacy reporters.
- ✓ **Multilingual access**
Language is a config setting per community. Yoruba and Nigerian English today.
- ✓ **Low bandwidth / limited access**
SMS only. Works on a feature phone that costs under ₦10,000, with no data plan.
- ✓ **Privacy & security**
An LLM is the first to read every report, stripping identity as it does, so identities are always protected; phone numbers are hashed, never stored in plain text; a protected line for reporting the guards.
- ✓ **Local relevance & next steps**
Every escalation is a structured brief to the community's own committee, never a public accusation.

WHAT'S NEXT

From a neighbourhood pilot to infrastructure

NEXT

Robust pattern matching

More reliable clustering as more communities and more report types come online.

NEXT

A real bridge to law enforcement

Not just a neighbourhood committee: a formal, structured handoff for the patterns that warrant it.

LATER

Voice intake

For reporters who'd rather speak than type.

LATER

More communities, more languages

Every new one is a config row: a number, a committee, a language.

CLOSING

The signal was always there. It just had nowhere to go.

Àkíyèsí gives the people standing closest to the street, the ones no WhatsApp group ever reached, a way to be heard before something happens, not just after.

TRACK

Stability & Social Cohesion

REPO

<https://github.com/black-fyre/osf-akiyesi>

BUILT BY

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